

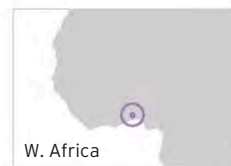
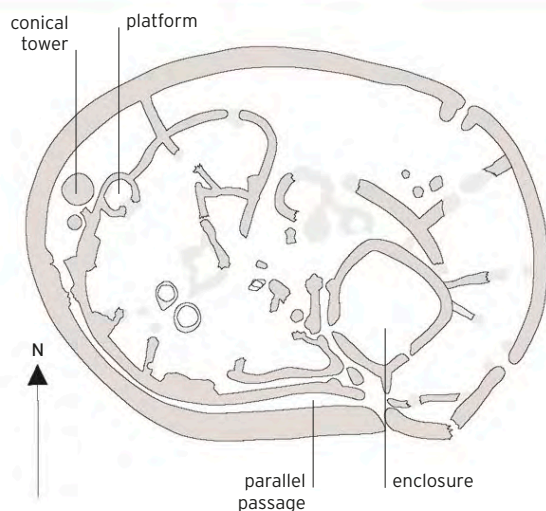


STURDY WALLS

This aerial view of the Great Enclosure shows the thick boundary and internal walls. The 33-ft- (10-m-) high conical tower is obscured by vegetation.

THE GREAT ENCLOSURE

The Great Enclosure is the largest structure in Great Zimbabwe. Its circular 16-ft- (5-m-) thick wall has a circumference of 820 ft (250 m) and was built from 900,000 granite blocks. Within the wall, a narrow passage leads to a solid conical tower, over 16 ft (5 m) in diameter at the base and over 30 ft (9 m) tall. It also has a series of further enclosures, community areas, and *daga*-hut living quarters.



Royal Palaces of Abomey

A palace complex built between the 17th and 19th centuries by the powerful kings of the vanished West African kingdom of Dahomey

From 1625 to 1900, the Kingdom of Dahomey was one of the most powerful in West Africa, its success built largely on trading slaves with Europeans. At their capital in Abomey in modern-day Benin, the 12 successive kings of Dahomey constructed a vast complex of royal palaces, covering 5,000,000 square ft (470,000 square m).



△ SYMBOLIC SCULPTURE

This detail from one of the colorful bas-relief earthen panels at the Abomey palaces shows a lion, the symbol of King Glélé (r.1858-1889).

Many purposes

Built as a series of courtyards, the palaces included the royal mausoleums, religious buildings, and council and public meeting rooms. They were both the administrative center of the kingdom and its treasury and cultural heart, decorated with colored bas-relief earthen panels depicting the kingdom's battles, myths, beliefs, and customs. In 1892, the last independent king of Dahomey ordered his troops to burn the palaces but the 19th-century palaces of Ghezo and Glélé survived and have since been restored.



△ TRADITIONAL CONSTRUCTION

The courtyard and buildings of King Ghezo's palace were made from mud-brick, and the palace walls were decorated with bas-relief panels.